

Hope, expect, and possibility

Learner workbook

Separate what you want from what you think is likely.

Understand the distinction

Hope expresses a desired outcome. Expect expresses a belief about what is likely. May, might, and could express possibility. Will can express a prediction, a decision, or willingness; context matters.

These words are not a fixed percentage scale. I hope it rains does not tell us how likely rain is. I expect a delay can express an unwelcome prediction. Keep facts, wishes, and uncertainty distinct.

Compare the patterns

WISH

I hope the train is on time.

This is the outcome I want.

EXPECTATION

I expect the train to be late.

This is what I think is likely.

POSSIBILITY

The train might be late.

A delay is possible, not certain.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which expresses a wish: I hope we win / I expect we will win?

2. Rewrite as a possibility: The office will close early.

3. Does I expect a problem mean I want one?

Use it in your own life

Write a hope and a cautious prediction about tomorrow.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. I hope we win.

Hope identifies a desired outcome.

2. The office might close early.

Might reduces the certainty. May or could also works.

3. No. It expresses a belief, not a wish.

An expectation can be unwelcome.

One possible response

I hope the weather is good. It might rain in the afternoon.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-08.html